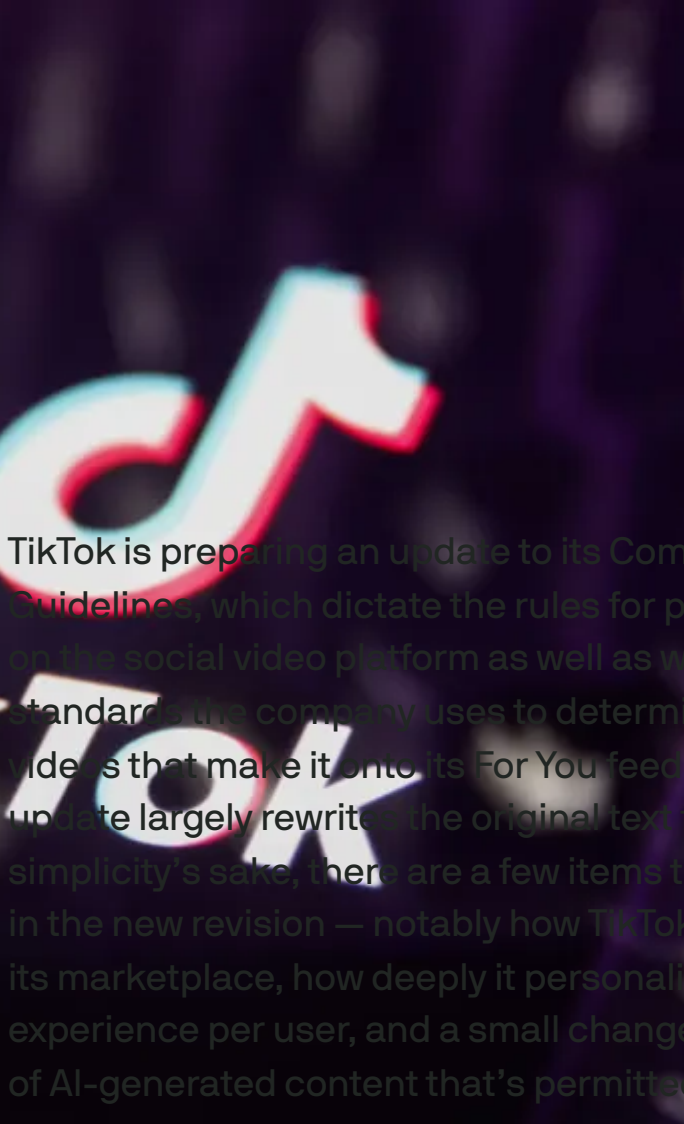


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SOCIAL



TikTok's new guidelines
add subtle changes for
LIVE creators, AI content,
and more



TikTok is preparing an update to its Community Guidelines, which dictate the rules for participating on the social video platform as well as what standards the company uses to determine the videos that make it onto its For You feed. While the update largely rewrites the original text for simplicity's sake, there are a few items that jump out in the new revision — notably how TikTok prioritizes its marketplace, how deeply it personalizes the experience per user, and a small change to the type of AI-generated content that's permitted.

Today, social media companies have to comply with a range of regulations globally, like the U.K.'s Online Safety Act (OSA), the EU's Digital Services Act (DSA), and the U.S.'s TAKE IT DOWN Act, which in part has led to policy revisions on some platforms, as with yesterday's [update to Bluesky](#).

TikTok's changes, which go live on September 13, 2025, are not as substantial, as it appears the company was often just rewriting text for clarity.

However, one section that saw several additions in the updated guidelines covers the [rules for TikTok LIVE creators](#).

The company warns creators they're responsible for anything that happens on their live session, even if it involves third-party tools, like real-time translation or voice-to-text tools to read out viewers' comments. TikTok advises creators to monitor those

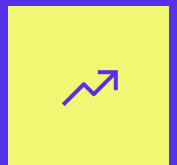
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tools to make sure they're not violating the rules through these third-party services.

Another notable addition to this section introduces new guidelines for commercial content.

TikTok stresses that commercial content must be disclosed. It also directly states that it will reduce the visibility of content that directs users to “purchase products off-platform in markets where TikTok Shop is available.”

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The company also says it's [customizing users' search results](#).

While the prior version of the guidelines said TikTok provided “search suggestions” that were relevant to the user, the new guidelines say both “search results and recommendations may look different for everyone.” The guidelines explain that TikTok uses information like your past searches and what you've watched to make the search results more relevant.

The updated rules reveal that [comments](#) are personalized, too.

TikTok says comments are being sorted based on signals like past replies, likes, and reports. Again, this means the comment section will look different from user to user.

The [section on AI content](#) has not changed dramatically, though the language here has become less verbose in parts when describing what sort of deepfake content is not allowed. TikTok previously banned content that “shares or shows fake authoritative sources or crisis events, or falsely shows public figures in certain contexts,” it said. “This includes being bullied, making an endorsement, or being endorsed.”

That’s now been replaced with language that says TikTok doesn’t allow content “that’s misleading about matters of public importance or harmful to individuals.”

It’s interesting to note the language referencing AI endorsements was removed. (Perhaps TikTok is paving the way for celebrity-approved, AI-generated endorsements?)

In some cases, the language in the guidelines has been simplified, such as in the case of the [For You feed \(FYF\) Eligibility Standards section](#), which no longer has [a long list of what’s considered FYF ineligible](#) content. Instead, details about the ineligible content are spread throughout the many different sections of the updated Community Guidelines, which makes it less helpful to reference since it’s no longer all in one place.

It’s also worth noting that TikTok changed the language explaining the reason why it engages in content moderation.

Before, the company said the process kept the platform “safe, trustworthy, and vibrant.” Now it describes content moderation as helping TikTok be a “safe, fun, and creative place for everyone.”

It seems “trustworthy” got the ax. *Uh-oh.*

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor |

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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APPS



TikTok’s latest feature
lets college students find

and connect with classmates

Aisha Malik — 6:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

In a move reminiscent of Facebook's early days, TikTok is launching a new feature that allows college students to find and connect with others on their campus. The feature, called Campus Verification, lets users add their college campus to their TikTok profile and browse a list of students at their school.

To access the feature, users need to navigate to their profile and tap the "Add school" button. From there, they need to enter their school name and then select their graduation year.

IMAGE CREDITS:
ARTUR WIDAK/NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

To verify that they actually go to the school they entered, they need to provide their academic email address. Once complete, their college name and graduation year will be displayed on their profile.

Users can then browse their school's page, filter by graduation year, and view all of the users who have added the school to their profile. They can also sort the users list to show the most-followed users first.

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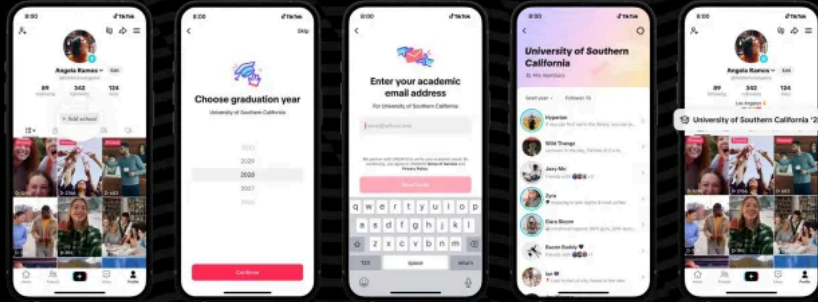


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IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

The feature is available across more than 6,000 universities through TikTok’s partnership with [UNiDAYS](#), a student verification platform that confirms student status.

TikTok says the idea behind the feature is to turn its platform into a hub for real-world connections and belonging on campus, which is essentially what Facebook’s original mission was when it launched in 2004 as a way for Harvard students to connect with one another.

TikTok’s new feature could be a welcome addition for college students looking to connect with others on campus. However, it also raises concerns about digital privacy, as it could make it easier for users to track others online. Of course, the feature is optional, so those who prefer to keep their TikTok presence separate from their student life can choose to simply not add their school to their profile.

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It's worth noting that the launch comes as Instagram was [spotted testing a similar feature](#) last year that would allow users to display their school info and graduation year on their profile and connect with other students. It's unknown if the feature was scrapped or if the Meta-owned platform still plans to roll it out.

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [in](#)

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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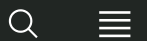


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X's declining Android app installs are hurting subscription revenue

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downloads on Google Play saw a significant decline, as new installs dropped by 44% year-over-year worldwide, even as iOS downloads grew by 15%.

This steep drop in installs is pulling down X's overall average, leading to a 26% decrease in total mobile downloads year-over-year as of July. That's still slightly better than the month prior, when total downloads had fallen by 35%, thanks to another

sharp drop in Android downloads, which were then down by nearly half (49%) year-over-year.

New X Downloads on Mobile by Month

Estimated Downloads • Worldwide • App Store and Google Play



IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

The firm didn't speculate on what's causing the decline on Android devices beyond suggesting that the X app on Android is known to be a sore spot for the company. Recently hired [X head of product Nikita Bier](#), known for growth hacking teen social apps like [Gas](#) and [TBH](#) (then [selling them](#)), has hinted that X is looking to address issues on Android, where its app is [notoriously buggy](#) and [often crashes](#).

In a post on the platform, Bier [announced](#) that X was hiring for its "Android Dream Team" to work on rebuilding the X Android app. He also recently posted that X's iOS app [had just seen a record week in terms of installs](#), perhaps hoping to draw attention away from the large Android slump.

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New X Downloads on Mobile by Month with Year-Over-Year Growth

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Month	App Store	YoY	Google Play	YoY	Unified	YoY
Jan-24	2,963,000	-	6,303,000	-	9,266,000	-
Feb-24	3,623,000	-	6,352,000	-	9,975,000	-
Mar-24	3,363,000	-	6,689,000	-	10,052,000	-
Apr-24	2,971,000	-	7,536,000	-	10,507,000	-
May-24	2,993,000	-	7,676,000	-	10,669,000	-
Jun-24	3,514,000	-	8,787,000	-	12,301,000	-
Jul-24	3,429,000	-	7,742,000	-	11,171,000	-
Aug-24	3,338,000	-	7,953,000	-	11,291,000	-
Sep-24	2,679,000	-	6,347,000	-	9,026,000	-
Oct-24	2,876,000	-	5,895,000	-	8,771,000	-
Nov-24	2,629,000	-	5,735,000	-	8,364,000	-
Dec-24	2,691,000	-	5,861,000	-	8,552,000	-
Jan-25	3,312,000	12%	6,019,000	-5%	9,331,000	1%
Feb-25	3,475,000	-4%	5,535,000	-13%	9,010,000	-10%
Mar-25	3,359,000	0%	6,814,000	2%	10,173,000	1%
Apr-25	3,029,000	2%	5,032,000	-33%	8,061,000	-23%
May-25	3,370,000	13%	4,766,000	-38%	8,136,000	-24%
Jun-25	3,531,000	0%	4,451,000	-49%	7,982,000	-35%
Jul-25	3,950,000	15%	4,334,000	-44%	8,284,000	-26%

Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

It’s not clear where would-be X Android users are going. Rival Bluesky has seen slowing growth in recent months, and its Google Play app pulled in just 119,000 downloads in July. That’s nowhere near the millions that install X on iOS or Android every month. However, Meta’s Threads daily active users have been [catching up to X on mobile devices](#), so, possibly, some Android users could be accounted for there.

In addition to the drop in Google Play installs, X is struggling to grow its subscription revenue, Appfigures found.

In July, X earned \$16.9 million in net revenue, down from the \$18.8 million it earned in March 2025. However, that was a slight tick up from the \$16.8 million it generated in June. (Of course, X still earns the majority of its overall revenue from ads, not in-app premium subscriptions.)

While the declining demand for X on Android is partially to blame for revenue declines, X is also

likely losing paying customers to Grok. The latter now has its own [stand-alone app](#) that attracts those who were buying X subscriptions primarily for the AI perks.

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AI crawler Firecrawl raises \$14.5M, is still looking to hire agents as employees

Julie Bort — 4:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Firecrawl's co-founder and CEO Caleb Peffer knew the exact moment he found the investor to lead his Series A.

He was in a coffee meeting with Nexus Venture Partner's Abhishek Sharma at the Blue Bottle in San Francisco's South Park (a favorite VC haunt). While describing the future of the company, he was gesturing so animatedly that his chair tipped over.

"I actually fell out of my chair. And Abhishek, as a great Investor does, caught the chair and me as I was falling," Peffer described with a laugh. That felt like a symbol for how the founder/investor relationship is supposed to work. "I think that was a clear signal that he was the right partner."

On Tuesday, Firecrawl announced a Series A led by Nexus with participation from Shopify CEO Tobias Lütke and existing investor Y Combinator.

Firecrawl offers a popular open-source web crawler for developers and AI agents, with a commercially

supported version available through API. It's used by 350,000 developers, has nearly [50,000 stars](#) on GitHub and its notable customers include Shopify, Replit, and Zapier as well as “some of the largest hedge funds in the world,” Pfeffer told TechCrunch. And, he says, the company is already profitable.

The startup also just released an API that supports search and will soon add support for natural language prompts, as co-founder and CTO Nicolas Silberstein Camara noted.

Pfeffer, who co-founded Firecrawl in 2022 with Camara and CMO Eric Ciarla, said gaining Lütke as an investor was “the best kind of validation.”



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They landed him through a gutsy email after discovering the Shopify founder had signed up to try their product through their self-service portal.

“We saw his email come in,” Pfeffer said. The Firecrawl crew immediately emailed him to welcome him as a customer, but got no response. Two

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months later, some Shopify folks contacted Firecrawl for an enterprise contract. So Pepper took his shot and emailed Lütke again, mentioning they'd love for him to participate in their upcoming round.

This time, Lütke responded with compliments about their product. He was in.

While AI web crawlers have [a somewhat dubious reputation these days](#), mostly due to bad actors [that ignore robot.txt files](#), they are also a necessary part of the burgeoning AI world. AI trains on the web, [agents need to access web pages to perform their duties](#), and enterprises need personalized crawlers to consume their own websites for training and operations.

The Firecrawl founders also hope to help address the frustrating parts of their industry. They are working on tools to help website owners, publishers, and other content creators “get paid when AI uses their content. We think this is the way it should be,” Pepper said.

While there have been lots of efforts around this idea from big names like [Adobe and Getty](#) as well as startups [like Bria, Calliope Networks](#), and others, Pepper feels that Firecrawl has an edge because it's already working with those who are scraping data.

“We already have one side of the marketplace,” he said. “What we want to do is just connect that side of the marketplace to the website owners, the publishers.”

Interestingly, Firecrawl also went viral a few months ago for reasons that have little to do with their open source tool. They had posted an [ad to the YC job board looking to hire an AI agent as an employee for a \\$15,000 salary](#) – perhaps the first job ad for an agent employee, ever.

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That job search didn't yield an agent worth hiring, so Firecrawl upped the budget to up [\\$1 million to hire several agents and the developers who built them, and tried again](#). Applicants flooded in, Peffer said, but the company hasn't yet hired any. The founders realized that evaluating and managing wanna-be agent employees is a job in itself. So now they are looking for an AI chief of staff.

Firecrawl's Peffer will [be on stage at Disrupt in October](#) to discuss all that he's learned in a session that covers the pros and cons of hiring AI agents as early employees.

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